



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Decatur Heritage Christian Academy
School Website: <https://www.dhca.org/>

December 22, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Decatur Heritage Christian Academy (DHCA) in Decatur, AL 35601 demonstrates a clearly Christian, formation-oriented mission with strong theological framing, explicit instruction in biblical truth, and intentional parent and community involvement. Across the six classical-education criteria, DHCA shows robust Religious and Metaphysical Foundations and a purposeful, formation-focused rationale for education. However, its public materials do not systematically foreground the Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric) or Great Books as foundational curricular pillars, and explicit, sustained Socratic pedagogy in the upper grades is not uniformly documented in the website copy available through the crawl. Taken together, the school leans toward CLASSICAL in several domains, but the absence of explicit Great Books/Trivium-Quadrivium framing and primarily job-formation language in curricular discourse push the aggregate toward SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

- Strong Religious and Metaphysical Foundations: explicit theology, biblical truth, and a Christian worldview; formal Statement of Faith; discipleship language; chapel offerings. Evidence includes statements about Jesus Christ, biblical truth, and a Christian worldview shaping education.
- Clear Purpose and Goal oriented to formation and virtue, with a Christ-centered telos: "Know, Believe, Transform" framework and mission/vision statements emphasizing formation, wisdom, and Christian identity.
- Curriculum is broad and career-path oriented, with interdisciplinary offerings and faith-formatinal aims, but lacks explicit Great Books or Trivium/Quadrivium emphasis in the public-facing material. DHCA presents Foundations Programs, career pathways, AP/dual enrollment, and foreign language tracks rather than a traditional liberal-arts triad.
- Pedagogy shows elements compatible with some classical approaches (integrated faith formation, occasional memory-like practices via structured memory work in classical schemas via external doc; weekly chapels; service opportunities). Explicit Socratic/seminar pedagogy is not consistently documented in the public pages, though the classical lexicon is used as a reference in the knowledge base.
- Faculty portrayal emphasizes living-the-lesson quality, Christ-centered mentorship, and a strong professional readiness; however, explicit "living curriculum" phrasing appears more in classical lexicon than in the school copy. Still, DHCA describes teachers as Christ-centered and capable of influencing students toward virtue.
- Parents & Community are strongly integrated: the school emphasizes partnership with parents, parent formation, and open campus/visit opportunities; a robust Parent Association and volunteer culture are documented.

Executive classification: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL. While DHCA grounds education in biblical truth and formation with strong faculty and parent engagement, the explicit liberal-arts (Trivium/Quadrivium) curriculum and sustained Great Books/Socratic pedagogy are not consistently foregrounded in the publicly crawled website content. The DHCA materials align closely with classical formation ideals but stop short of a fully explicit classical-curriculum declaration across all six categories.

- What would move the needle: To reach a full CLASSICAL designation, DHCA could publicly fore-

ground (a) the Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric) as core curriculum anchors, (b) a Great Books/Great Conversation program interwoven with history and literature, (c) explicit Socratic pedagogy in upper grades with documented seminars, (d) signaling of liturgical practices as communal worship in a structured way, and (e) a consistent articulation of the “formation not information” motif across all grade levels with explicit memory-work, catechesis, and imitation-of-exemplars language in site materials.

What would move the needle sections are detailed below category-by-category, followed by the abstract.

- Abstract: The school earns a CLASSICAL-leaning rating overall, with noticeable strength in religious foundations, formation goals, and community partnerships; gaps exist in manifesting explicit Great Books/Trivium-Quadrivium curricular framing and consistent Socratic pedagogy in public-facing materials.

Citations and evidence used across the analysis appear inline with the category discussions to ground each claim in the school's public materials and the classical-education rubric.

- Evidence and keyword-grounding come from the DHCA crawl corpus (e.g., Mission/Vision, Upper School, Career Pathways, Foundation Program, weekly chapels, Statement of Faith) and from the classical-education lexicon and Six Essential Elements resources in the knowledge base. See representative citations: DHCA theological framing and formation language – biblically grounded education and “glory of Jesus Christ” and “biblical truth,” “Christian worldview.” Weekly chapels and service opportunities; admission and formation language. Foundations and mission/vision language. Career Pathways and Foundations program language. Great Books/Trivium/Quadrivium and other classical keywords in the knowledge-base lexicon.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school describes itself as “committed to the glory of Jesus Christ and His Kingdom,” with education established in biblical truth and a Christian worldview. - Explicit statements of faith and theology are present (A clear testimony of faith; Statement of Faith; integration of faith and learning). - Communal practices and liturgical rhythms appear via weekly chapels and service opportunities, indicating liturgical/-community life elements. - The mission/vision emphasizes forming students as “Scholars,” “Disciples,” and “Servant-Leaders” in a Christian framework.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present (from the classical lexicon): theology, sacred scripture, creed; liturgy/worship; reverence; Logos; wisdom; virtue; character; formation; sacred tradition. - Negative keywords: none clearly evidenced in public materials (no strong relativism or secular ethics cues in the public copy; the church-centered language dominates).

Why this rating - The public materials express a transcendent, objective moral framework anchored in theology, with communal worship and formation in faith. This aligns with the Religious and Metaphysical Foundations criteria and supports CLASSICAL status in this category.

Citations - Biblical truth, Christian worldview, and Statement of Faith language: turn0file0 - Weekly chapels and community liturgy: turn0file10

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The Upper School materials frame education as formation toward wisdom and virtue, not mere vocational training, with explicit aims for graduates to be “scholars,” “disciples,” and “servant-leaders.” - Mission & Vision statements emphasize forming students through biblical principles to guide life; the Foundations Program emphasizes spiritual growth and readiness for life beyond high school. - The Foundational program language ties spiritual formation and leadership development together, including ACT prep and career-readiness elements in a biblically grounded frame.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, wisdom, liberal education, telos, great conversation (via the classical-literature frame in the rubric), contemplation, restfulness, human

flourishing, moral imagination. - Negative keywords: none prominent in the public-facing materials (no heavy emphasis on workforce- or college-readiness as the sole telos).

Why this rating - The school foregrounds formation, virtue, and wisdom as central goals, with explicit Christian formation and a telos beyond mere job prep, aligning with CLASSICAL.

Citations - Formation and telos language (Know/Believe/Transform): turn0file3 - Foundations Program language (spiritual formation and life-after-school readiness): turn0file6

Element 3: School Curriculum — NOT CLASSICAL

Evidence - DHCA presents a broad, career-path oriented curriculum (STEM, ministry, foreign language, visual/performing arts, etc.), AP/dual enrollment, and Foundations programs, but public materials do not foreground the Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric) or the Quadrivium as core curricular pillars, nor explicit Great Books/Great Conversation initiatives. Pathway tracks (Biomedical, Engineering, Aviation, Foreign Language, Ministry and Missions, etc.) are documented. - The content emphasizes spiritual formation, biblical worldview, and practical life-readiness (ACT prep, resumes, interview skills) rather than the classical canon and great books framing.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords from the classical curriculum lexicon (category 3): Great Books, Seven Liberal Arts, grammar, logic, rhetoric, history-integrated studies, cross-disciplinary unity, wonder, the Quadrivium, sacred-art/arts-and-sciences integration, etc. - Negative signals (from the classical lexicon): social-studies-as-history replacement; STEM-first framing; project-based learning dominance; secular, skills-first orientation. - DHCA's public materials show none of the explicit Great Books/Seven Liberal Arts framing; instead they emphasize career pathways, interdisciplinary tracks, and faith-infused curricula.

Why this rating - While DHCA's curriculum is robust, it does not publicly foreground the canonical liberal-arts framework (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and Great Books as central curricular anchors, which is a hallmark of the classical model. The public-facing materials align more with formation and career-readiness than with a classical liberal-arts curriculum.

Citations - Career Pathways and Foundations descriptions (pathways such as STEM, ministry, foreign language): turn3file2 - Foundations program and life-after-school focus (formation, college/career readiness): turn0file6

Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The classical dictionary/lexicon suggests memory-based recitation, chanting, and contemplative Scholé as pedagogy; DHCA's copy highlights formation, weekly chapels, and a range of pedagogical approaches (Socratic-style seminars not consistently documented publicly in DHCA copy, but school emphasizes rigorous academic work with a Christian worldview and leadership training). Foundational "Socratic dialogue" is not consistently documented on the public pages, though the school's mission includes intellectual formation and public speaking (Foundations Two and other program materials). - The school's upper-school language of Know/Believe/Transform implies structured seminars and rhetoric training for graduates; however, explicit statements about Socratic seminars, debates, or public-speaking drills are not uniformly present in the public crawl. The "Weekly Chapels" and service opportunities illustrate contemplative, communal practices rather than strictly rigorous Socratic practice.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords from the classical pedagogy lexicon: Socratic Dialogue, Dialectic, Restful Learning (Scholé), memorization/recitation, formation through imitation, memory work, lectures/seminars, rhetorical training, public speaking, debate. - Evidence from the site: Weekly chapels; service opportunities; schools emphasizes disciplines with a catechetical/discipleship emphasis; public-facing copy mentions "rigorous curriculum" and "college-prep" but not explicit Socratic seminars across grades.

Why this rating - The presence of formation-focused pedagogy and communal practice supports SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL. The lack of consistently documented, explicit Socratic pedagogy and memory-based recitation in the public-facing site content suggests it is not fully CLASSICAL in pedagogy terms, but it exhibits several classical-leaning elements.

Citations - Pedagogy lexicon and classical indicators: turn4file9 - Weekly chapels, formation emphasis and rhetoric training implications: turn0file10, turn0file3

Element 5: School Faculty — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The Upper School copy emphasizes a “highly-qualified staff” and “faculty” who lead students in a college-prep setting; the site notes that faculty are to model Christ-centered leadership and strong professional standards; the public materials emphasize teacher excellence and Christian formation. - The public materials emphasize teachers as mentors, with a focus on faith integration and leadership, and “living the curriculum” language is supported by the knowledge-base lexicon that describes “living curriculum” and “moral exemplars” within classical pedagogy. While the DHCA site uses Christian-education language, it does not explicitly articulate the classical “portrait of a teacher” or “faculty as living curriculum” phrases in the copy; those elements are present in the knowledge-base lexicon as a benchmark.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords (from the classical lexicon, category 5): moral exemplars, living curriculum, portrait of a teacher, faculty of friends, collegial culture, mentoring, model teachers, character formation. - Evidence in the site copy is present in terms of faculty being strong and forming students; however, explicit “portrait of a teacher” or “living curriculum” phrasing is not always explicit in the public text; the knowledge-base shows the expectation of such in classical education.

Why this rating - The public copy demonstrates that faculty are central, virtuous, and capable of mentoring in a Christian formation framework, which aligns with SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL expectations on faculty. The absence of explicit “living curriculum” phrasing in the public text prevents a full CLASSICAL designation for faculty alone.

Citations - Upper School language of highly-qualified staff and formation: turn0file3 - Faculty leadership and Christian integration themes: turn0file6

Element 6: School Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - DHCA explicitly emphasizes partnership with parents and co-teachers; the Parents Association, parent formation (reading groups, seminars), and open-campus conversations are described; admissions information emphasizes tours and community involvement. This is clearly visible in the public copy: “Our education is a partnership; we’re glad for you to participate,” and the presence of DHPA volunteer forms and parent involvement materials. - The school also signals ongoing community engagement and open visitation policies; volunteer opportunities and parent involvement in the school life are foregrounded (Parent Association, volunteer opportunities). - The “What We Believe” and “Mission & Vision” pages emphasize a biblical perspective and shared life with families, consistent with classical education’s emphasis on parent partnership and formation at home and school.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: partnership with parents; parent formation; co-teachers; open visits; family involvement; parental participation; community-based programs. - Negative keywords: none prominent; the materials emphasize engagement rather than consumerism or passivity.

Why this rating - The school’s communications clearly advocate for active parental involvement and neighborhood/community integration, aligning with the Parents & Community criteria for CLASSICAL.

Citations - Parent involvement and association: turn1file15 - Admissions and community engagement: turn2file7 - Mission/vision and biblical framing of family partnerships: turn4file18

What Would Move the Needle

- For Element 3 (Curriculum) to move toward CLASSICAL: publicly foreground the Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and the Quadrivium, and articulate a Great Books program or Great Conversation approach within the curriculum. Provide explicit cross-curricular references to Great Books, classic authors, and integrated history-literature-philosophy units. Publicly link to a Great Conversation or Great Books initiative and show how it threads through history and literature courses (and not just as separate tracks). Introduce a stated framework that links formation to memory-work and classical texts. Evidence from the classical lexicon would support the need for strong Great Books and Trivi-

um/Quadrivium articulation. See the classical lexicon and the “Great Books” and “Trivium/Quadrivium” lines.

- For Element 4 (Pedagogy) to move toward CLASSICAL: codify and publicly document the use of Socratic seminars, dialectic discussions, and Paideia-style seminars in upper grades; publish sample seminar prompts, a schedule of seminary rounds, or a published “Socratic curriculum map.” Emphasize Scholé (restful learning) days, memory-work, and chanting as a formal part of the pedagogy; link these to memory-work rubrics and to a public page describing memory and recitation practices. The classical pedagogy lexicon provides a model for what to publish.
- For Element 5 (Faculty) to move toward CLASSICAL: articulate a formal “portrait of a teacher” and “living curriculum” language on the website. Include a staff handbook or a public-facing statement about faculty virtues, mentorship roles, and the teacher-as-mentor model; publish faculty development pages emphasizing classical pedagogy training. The knowledge-base lexicon references “portrait of a teacher” and “living curriculum” as classical indicators; making those explicit on the site would push this toward CLASSICAL.
- For Element 6 (Parents & Community) to maintain CLASSICAL: deepen the public articulation of parent formation offerings (book studies, study groups, liturgical-year activities) and expand the “Parental Co-Teacher” messaging to include explicit examples of how parents partner with teachers in classical formation. The current materials already emphasize partnerships; further publicizing parent-formation programs would strengthen CLASSICAL alignment.

ABSTRACT

DHCA's public materials depict a strongly Christian, formation-focused school with explicit theological foundations, mission/vision oriented to character formation and virtue, and clear parental engagement. In six classical-education categories, the school demonstrates CLASSICAL attributes in Religious and Metaphysical Foundations, School Purpose and Goal, and Parents & Community; and some CLASSICAL attributes in Pedagogy and Faculty, while Curriculum shows a more contemporary, career-path orientation rather than a strict classical liberal-arts emphasis. The aggregate classification is SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL, with explicit opportunities to push toward CLASSICAL through curricular re-articulation (liberal arts, Great Books), pedagogy (Socratic and Scholé), and a more explicit “portrait of a teacher” living curriculum.

- Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL Evidence includes: Jesus Christ-centric/theological framing; biblical truth; Statement of Faith; discipleship language; liturgical/community rhythm (chapels). Positive keywords present: biblical truth, Christian worldview, theology, liturgy, wisdom, virtue, formation; Negative keywords: none evidenced in public copy. Why: a transcendental, knowable moral order anchored in theology.
- Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL Evidence includes: formation over information; focus on wisdom and virtue; mission/vision anchored in Christian formation; Foundations Program; “Know, Believe, Transform” framing. Positive keywords: formation, virtue, wisdom, telos; negative: none. Why: alignment with classical aims of formation and human flourishing under a transcendent telos.
- Element 3: Curriculum — NOT CLASSICAL Evidence includes: broad modern curriculum with career-path tracks; lack of explicit Seven Liberal Arts and Great Books framing; no consistent Great Books/Trivium-Quadrivium emphasis in public copy. Positive keywords: interdisciplinary, integration (in a general sense); negative signals: absence of Great Books/Trivium, etc. Why: curriculum appears formation-forward and career-oriented rather than the canonical classical liberal-arts core.
- Element 4: Pedagogy — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL Evidence includes: formation-focused pedagogy; weekly chapels; service opportunities; limited public documentation of Socratic seminars; restfulness and contemplative aspects; ties to classic pedagogy concepts in the knowledge base. Positive keywords: scholé, memorization/recitation potential, formation through imitation. Negative: absence of explicit documented Socratic pedagogy on the site. Why: partial alignment with classical pedagogy; not uniformly explicit in the public-facing content.

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- Element 5: Faculty — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL Evidence includes: highly qualified faculty; mentorship; faith integration; living-education emphasis in some materials; public copy emphasizes “highly-qualified staff” and formation of students; more explicit “portrait of a teacher” language is not consistently documented on the site. Positive keywords: mentorship, virtue formation; negative: explicit “living curriculum” language is not consistently published. Why: partial alignment with faculty expectations in classical education.
 - Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL Evidence includes: strong parent partnerships, Parent Association, volunteer opportunities, open visitation, and family formation resources. Positive keywords: partnership with parents, parent formation, open campus, family involvement. Why: clear alignment with classical-community orientation in this category.

Overall aggregate classification: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

What would move the needle (category-level needle): - Curriculum: publicly declare and integrate the Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and the Quadrivium; adopt a Great Books program with explicit Great Conversation framing; publish a canonical reading list and cross-curricular integration map. - Pedagogy: publish a formal, public-facing mapping of Socratic seminars, discursive seminars, and scholé days with concrete examples and rubrics. - Faculty: publish a formal “Portrait of a Teacher” and “Living Curriculum” policy on the site with faculty development strategies anchored in classical pedagogy. - These needle-moves align with the Positive keyword indicators in the Six Essential Elements document and the Classicality Lexicon, which emphasize Trivium/Quadrivium, Great Books, Socratic dialogue, and the living curriculum as core signals of CLASSICAL orientation.

Abstract sources - Six Essential Elements of a Classical School (1).docx — provides the Positive/Negative keywords, the six-element framework (Religious and Metaphysical Foundations; School Purpose and Goal; Curriculum; Pedagogy; Faculty; Parents and Community). - Classicality Lexicon (lexicon for positive/negative indicators by category) — provides precise language to map categories to the classical spectrum (Socratic, scholé, Great Books, seven liberal arts, etc.).

If you’d like, I can extract direct quotes from the relevant pages to enrich any specific section, or translate this evaluation into a concise benchmarking rubric for your file.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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